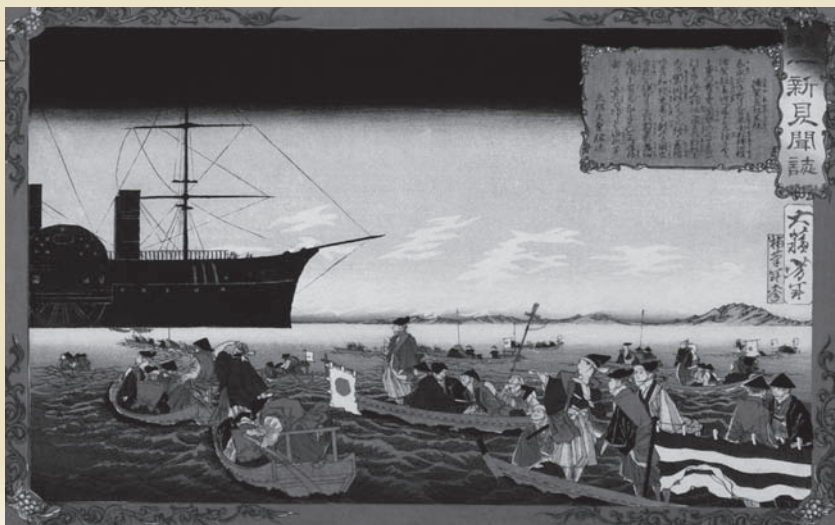




The shock of the new

When a US coal-fired gunship carrying modern weaponry entered Edo harbor on July 8, 1853 (above), the Japanese realized how backward their 220-year policy of isolation had made them. The country soon embarked on a rapid process of Westernization.

with the US, replacing an agreement with the UK and marking a shift in power in the Pacific.

1923 Yokohama earthquake kills 140,000 people.

1927 Japan enters a period of radical nationalism, and introduces the notion of a “coprosperity sphere” in southeast Asia under Japanese control. This is interpreted in the US as a threat to its Pacific interests.

1931 Chinese Manchuria is invaded and the puppet state of Manchukuo is set up.

1932 The country's political leaders hand over power to the militarists.

1936 Japan signs a pact with Nazi Germany.

1937 Japan launches a full-scale invasion of China proper.

1938 All political parties are placed under one common banner. Japan is now effectively ruled by militarists.

1939 In an undeclared border war with the USSR, Japan is defeated.

1940 Japan occupies French Indochina.

1941 The US imposes a trade embargo, including oil, on Japan, thereby threatening to derail its military machine. Japan responds in December by launching an attack on the US fleet at Pearl Harbor, Hawaii, and invading US, UK, and Dutch possessions in the Pacific.

1942 Japan loses the decisive naval battle of Midway.

1945 Huge US bombing campaign culminates in dropping of atomic bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki. The USSR declares war on Japan. Emperor Hirohito surrenders. Japan is placed under the control of a US military government with General Douglas MacArthur installed as Supreme Commander in Japan.

1946 In a radio broadcast to the nation on January 1, Emperor Hirohito renounces his traditional divine status.

1947 A new Japanese constitution is ratified. The emperor is retained as head of state in a ceremonial role. Pacifism is written into the constitution, as Japan renounces the use of force to resolve international disputes.

1948 Tojo Hideki, prime minister during World War II, is executed along with six others for war crimes. High executives of the largest industrial firms are removed from their positions.

1950 US army contracts resulting from the Korean War lead to rapid expansion of the Japanese economy.

1952 The Treaty of San Francisco officially marks the end of World War II and Japan regains independence. Industrial production recovers to 15 percent above 1936 levels. A 20-year period of rapid economic growth begins.

1955 A new political party, the Liberal-Democratic Party (LDP), is formed from a merger of several conservative parties. The LDP governs for the next 38 years.

1956 Japan joins the UN and reestablishes relations with the USSR.

1964 Tokyo hosts the Olympics. The first Shinkansen (bullet train) service linking Tokyo to Osaka is opened to coincide with the Olympics. Japan is admitted to the OECD.

1970 Acclaimed writer Yukio Mishima seizes control of a military headquarters in Tokyo, and commits *seppuku* (ritual suicide) to protest the Westernization of Japan. The Osaka World Exhibition showcases Japan's technological prowess.

1972 Prime Minister Tanaka Kakuei visits Beijing and Japan officially recognizes the People's Republic of China.

1973 Economic growth stalls as the price of oil quadruples. It is decided to concentrate investment in high-tech industries to reduce the country's dependence on oil imports.

1976 LDP shaken by the Lockheed bribery scandal, when it is revealed that senior Japanese politicians accepted

money in return for aircraft contracts. Prime Minister Tanaka Kakuei resigns. In the subsequent election, the LDP remains in power but loses its outright majority.

1979 The second world oil crisis affects Japan much less and growth continues at 6 percent per year.

1980 The LDP regains an overall majority in national elections.

1982 Honda establishes its first car factory in the US, in Marysville, Ohio.

1988 Japan becomes the world's largest aid donor and overseas investor.

1989 Emperor Hirohito dies and is succeeded by his son, Akihito. The Recruit-Cosmos bribery scandal leads to the resignation of prime minister Noburo Takeshita. He is replaced by Sosuke Uno, who is in turn forced to resign over a sexual scandal. The Tokyo stock market crashes shortly after the Nikkei 225 had reached a record high of 39,000.

1990 An immigration law comes into effect opening up the Japanese labor market to foreign workers for the first time ever. This is an attempt to solve the country's chronic labor shortages.

1991 Japan pledges billions of dollars in support of Operation Desert Storm in Kuwait and Iraq. The Nikkei 225 falls to 15,000, less than half its highest value.

1991–92 The LDP is torn by factional disputes, further financial scandals, and the issue of electoral reform.

1993 Reformists split from the LDP and create new parties. In elections, the LDP loses power. Morihiro Hosokawa becomes prime minister at the head of a seven-party coalition. Arrests of 165 political leaders and 445 business people for suspected electoral fraud.

1994 Hosokawa resigns. The withdrawal of the Social Democratic Party of Japan (SDPJ) causes the coalition government



Michinomiya Hirohito

Emperor of Japan from 1926 until his death in 1989, the myopic Hirohito was worshipped as a living god until 1946. His broadcast on August 15, 1945, signaled Japan's surrender in World War II.

to collapse. A new three-party coalition includes the LDP and SDPJ. Tomiichi Murayama becomes first socialist prime minister in 50 years.

1995 The Kobe earthquake kills more than 5,000 people, and leaves over 300,000 homeless. Members of the religious group Aum Shinrikyo attack the Tokyo subway with deadly gas, killing 12 people and injuring hundreds.

1996 LDP forms a minority government.

1997 Severe economic recession rocks Southeast Asia. As the major creditor country of the region, Japan suffers.

1998 Crisis over reform of the banking and financial system.

2000 Prime Minister Keizo Obuchi falls into a coma, and is replaced by Yoshiro Mori. LDP with coalition partners retains majority in June general election. Unemployment over 5 percent for the first time since the end of World War II.

2001 The LDP turns to populist right-winger Junichiro Koizumi as prime minister. He controversially pays homage at a shrine to Japan's war dead. Tanaka Makiko becomes Japan's first woman foreign minister.

2002 Japan cohosts the soccer World Cup with South Korea, the first World Cup to be held in Asia.

2003 Japan sends troops to support the US-led invasion of Iraq, the first time Japanese soldiers have been deployed in a war zone since the end of World War II.

2005 Prime Minister Junichiro Koizumi calls a general election two years early after bills to privatize Japan Post are voted down in the upper house. The ruling LDP is reelected in a landslide victory.

2006 Shinzo Abe becomes prime minister. Japan establishes its first formal Defense Ministry since World War II.

2007 The ruling LDP suffers severe defeat in upper house elections; Yasuo Fukuda becomes prime minister.

2009 Global financial crisis: Japan's economy shrinks 3.3 percent in a single quarter. The Democratic Party of Japan wins landslide election victory, ending 50 years of LDP rule. Yukio Hatoyama of the DPJ becomes prime minister.

2010 Hatoyama quits as PM and is replaced by Finance Minister Naoto Kan.

2011 A massive earthquake off the northeast coast of Honshu is followed by a devastating tsunami. Nuclear power plant at Fukushima suffers serious damage and radiation leaks.

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«242–43 Japan's Great Peace
«356–57 Rising Sun
«404–05 Hiroshima
«456–57 Tiger Economies